MODULE 08 · DOMAIN 2 - OUTPUT EVALUATION AND VALIDATION

Fact-Checking and Validation

Turning a plausible draft into a verified one: the review sequence, where to check each kind of claim, and what to do when sources disagree.

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Plausible means it **could** be true. Verified means you have **checked** that it is.

Reads well, or checks out?

PLAUSIBILITY

A CV that reads well

- Confident and fluent
- Internally consistent
- Matches what you expected
- No evidence behind it yet

VERIFICATION

Taking up the references

- Each claim traced to a source
- Figures recomputed
- Citations opened and read
- Checked by someone accountable

THE TIEBREAKER

The deciding question: can each specific claim be traced to a credible source or the material supplied?

The fact-checking sequence

01

Read end to end

Flag anything that surprises you.

02

List the claims

Facts, figures, quotes, citations.

03

Cross-check

Each against a source.

04

Document

Location and severity.

05

Decide

Correct, re-prompt or escalate.

ON THE EXAM

Read, list, check, document, then decide. The decision always comes last.

Where to check each kind of claim

CLAIM	CHECK IT AGAINST
A figure from your own data	The source file, recomputed
A quote	The original document, word for word
A citation	The cited work itself, opened and read
Law, regulation, official rates	The official publication or regulator
A fact about your organisation	Your system of record, not memory
Something recent	A current, authoritative source

ON THE EXAM

Check each claim against the most authoritative source for that kind of claim.

Go to the primary source

- **Three articles quoting one study are one source**, not three.
- **Repetition is not confirmation.** Figures drift as they are copied: rounded, re-dated, re-scoped.
- **Find the original.** Check the figure, its date, and what it actually measured.
- **Can't find it?** Then the claim stays unverified, however often it is repeated.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Repeated claims are checked at the primary source, not by counting how many times they appear.

When sources disagree

TEMPTING SHORTCUTS

Choose by convenience

- Go with the majority
- Take the most recent
- Split the difference
- Ask Claude to pick one

SOUND METHOD

Go up the chain

- Find the authoritative source
- Check its date and scope
- Use what it confirms
- Note the conflict you resolved

THE TIEBREAKER

When sources conflict, neither vote nor average. Go to the authoritative source.

Checking claims from the web

- **Read laterally.** Leave the page and see what others say about the source.
- **Who published it, and when?** A regulator, a vendor selling something, an anonymous blog?
- **Open the citations.** A link is a pointer, not proof. Check that it says what is claimed.
- **Research mode cites its sources.** That makes checking faster. It does not do the checking.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A citation tells you where to look. Only reading it tells you whether the claim is supported.

Let Claude help you verify

- **Quote or retract:** "For each claim, quote the passage that supports it. Remove any claim you cannot support."
- **Flag gaps:** "List every figure in this summary that does not appear in the attached files."
- **Fresh eyes:** in a new chat, ask Claude to review the draft against the sources as a sceptical checker.
- **Then spot-check the check.** Open a sample of the quotes and confirm they say what is claimed.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Claude can make a draft auditable. A person still audits it.

Numbers: recompute, don't re-read

RE-READING

Looking at the totals again

- Totals look sensible
- Claude says they are right
- Nobody recalculated

RECOMPUTING

Running the sums for real

- Code execution recalculates from the file
- Compare with the draft's figures
- Sanity-check against expected ranges

THE TIEBREAKER

Arithmetic done in prose is checked with real calculation, not another read-through.

Document findings by severity

SEVERITY	EXAMPLES	HANDLING
Critical	Wrong price, false legal claim	Fix before use; escalate
Major	Unsourced key claim	Fix or source it
Minor	Typo, formatting	Fix if time allows

ON THE EXAM

Record each finding with its location and severity, so the decision can rest on the record.

After documenting: correct, re-prompt or escalate

- **Correct it yourself** when the error is small, clear, and you know the right answer.
- **Re-prompt with sources** when errors are systematic: missing material, wrong scope.
- **Escalate** when the impact is high, or the fix needs expertise or authority you lack.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Small and clear: fix. Systematic: fix the inputs. High stakes or beyond you: escalate.

A Halden recruitment pack drafted with Claude states the current national minimum hourly rate for adult workers. The pack goes to nine hundred new recruits a year.

The recruiter wants to confirm the figure is right before it is printed.

Which source should she use to confirm it?

A. A recruitment blog that lists this year's pay rates

B. The official government publication of the current rate

C. Claude's own answer, asked again in a new chat

D. A competitor's job advert that quotes the same rate

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which source should she use to confirm it?

A. A recruitment blog that lists this year's pay rates
Secondary, and may be out of date or wrong.

B. The official government publication of the current rate
The authoritative source for an official rate.

C. Claude's own answer, asked again in a new chat
Same model, same knowledge cutoff. Not independent.

D. A competitor's job advert that quotes the same rate
Agreement with another secondary source is not verification.

THE SIGNAL

An official rate is confirmed at the official source.

A Claude-drafted briefing for Halden's site supervisors explains a new workplace recycling rule. Two sources it drew on give different dates for when the rule takes effect.

Supervisors will use the date to plan changes at client sites.

Which approach is correct?

A Use the later of the two dates, to give supervisors more time

B Use whichever date appears in more of the sources found

C Check the official government guidance, use the date it confirms, and note the conflict

D Ask Claude to decide which of the two dates is more likely

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which approach is correct?

A Use the later of the two dates, to give supervisors more time

If the earlier date is right, sites would be non-compliant.

B Use whichever date appears in more of the sources found

A vote. Many sources can share one wrong origin.

C Check the official government guidance, use the date it confirms, and note the conflict

Resolves the conflict at the authoritative source, and records it.

D Ask Claude to decide which of the two dates is more likely

A guess about which guess is right.

THE SIGNAL

Conflicting sources on a legal date: go to the authoritative source.

A Halden analyst is fact-checking a Claude-drafted market briefing before it goes to the board.

She will finish by deciding whether to correct the briefing, re-prompt Claude with better sources, or escalate.

Which two steps must come before that decision? Choose two.

A. Identify the specific factual claims, figures and citations in the briefing

B. Send the briefing to the board for early comments

C. Ask Claude to rate the accuracy of its own briefing

D. Cross-check each claim against the sources or trusted references

E. Publish a correction notice for any errors

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two steps must come before that decision? Choose two.

A Identify the specific factual claims, figures and citations in the briefing

You cannot check claims you have not listed.

B Send the briefing to the board for early comments

Sends unchecked material to the audience it is meant to protect.

C Ask Claude to rate the accuracy of its own briefing

Self-assessment is not part of verification.

D Cross-check each claim against the sources or trusted references

The check itself, which the decision rests on.

E Publish a correction notice for any errors

Comes after the decision, if at all.

THE SIGNAL

List the claims, check the claims, then decide.

> Claude summarised Halden's month-end workbook, with twelve tabs of site costs, and gave regional totals in its written reply.
>
> The finance director will present the totals to investors next week.

How should the totals be validated?

A. Re-read the summary carefully, looking for anything that seems off

B. Recompute the totals with code execution on the workbook, and compare

C. Ask Claude to confirm that its totals are correct

D. Round the totals, so small errors do not matter

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should the totals be validated?

A Re-read the summary carefully, looking for anything that seems off

A wrong total that looks sensible survives any re-read.

B Recompute the totals with code execution on the workbook, and compare

Real calculation against the source file.

C Ask Claude to confirm that its totals are correct

Self-confirmation repeats the original method.

D Round the totals, so small errors do not matter

Hides errors rather than finding them.

THE SIGNAL

Totals produced in prose, going to investors: recompute against the file.

> Claude summarised Halden's forty-page lone-working policy into two pages for supervisors. The safety manager must sign it off today.
>
> She wants Claude's help to check the summary quickly, without losing rigour.

Which prompt best supports her verification?

A "Is this summary accurate?"

B "Make the summary more detailed, so nothing is missed."

C "For each statement, quote the policy passage that supports it, and flag any you cannot support."

D "Rewrite the summary in plainer English."

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which prompt best supports her verification?

A "Is this summary accurate?"
Invites a yes. Gives her nothing to check.

B "Make the summary more detailed, so nothing is missed."
Adds more to verify, not a way to verify it.

C "For each statement, quote the policy passage that supports it, and flag any you cannot support."
Makes the summary auditable, line by line.

D "Rewrite the summary in plainer English."
A style change, not a check.

THE SIGNAL

Quote-per-claim turns a quick sign-off into a real one.

> Reviewing a Claude-drafted client proposal, a Halden bid manager finds a typo, an out-of-date reference to the old logo, and a weekly price that contradicts Halden's rate card.
>
> The proposal is due with the client tomorrow.

How should she handle the findings?

A Fix the typo first, because it is the quickest to resolve

B Send it, since all three are small issues

C Log all three as equally important and fix them in page order

D Record each with its location and severity, and resolve the price as critical before it goes out

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should she handle the findings?

A Fix the typo first, because it is the quickest to resolve

Orders work by ease, not by impact.

B Send it, since all three are small issues

A wrong price in a proposal is not small. It may bind Halden.

C Log all three as equally important and fix them in page order

Treats a typo like a pricing error.

D Record each with its location and severity, and resolve the price as critical before it goes out

Documents properly and puts the critical fix first.

THE SIGNAL

A price that contradicts the rate card is critical. Severity decides the order.

In five lines

- **Plausible is not verified.** Trace each claim to a credible source or the supplied material.
- **Sequence:** read, list the claims, cross-check, document, then decide.
- **Primary sources:** three articles quoting one study are one source.
- **Conflicts:** do not vote or average. Go to the authoritative source.
- **Recompute numbers**; have Claude quote or retract; record severity.

COMING UP

Next: when a human must review, and how to decide whether to escalate.